

Φιλόστρατος ὁ Ἀθηναῖος

Philostratus Athenian and the Images

eul_aid: rlw

Period: *Ῥωμαϊκή* [Roman](#)

Dialect: *Κοινή* [Koine](#)

Domain: *Βίος* [Biography](#)

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Philostratus, known as Philostratus the Athenian or the Elder, was a Greek sophist and author of the late second and early third centuries CE. He was a prominent figure within the Roman Empire's cultural movement known as the Second Sophistic. Born into a family of sophists on Lemnos, he studied rhetoric in Athens and later joined the literary circle of Empress Julia Domna in Rome. It was at her request that he began his famed *Life of Apollonius of Tyana*. His career flourished under the Severan emperors, and he is distinguished from his nephew, Philostratus the Younger, a writer on art.

His major works include the *Life of Apollonius of Tyana*, a lengthy, novelistic biography of the Neopythagorean sage; the *Lives of the Sophists*, a key source on Greek orators; the dialogue *Heroicus* on Trojan War heroes; the treatise *Gymnasticus* on athletic training; and the *Love Letters*. The *Imagines*, a collection of descriptions of paintings, is traditionally attributed to him, though sometimes assigned to his son-in-law.

Philostratus is a central literary figure of the Second Sophistic. His *Life of Apollonius* became a key text in pagan-Christian polemics, while his *Lives of the Sophists* is an invaluable historical source for Greek intellectual life under Rome. His corpus collectively helped shape the posterity of Greek paideia.

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